

Michael Joseph Jackson (August 29, 1958 – June 25, 2009) was an American singer, songwriter, dancer, and philanthropist. Dubbed the "King of Pop", Jackson is widely regarded as one of the most culturally significant figures of the 20th century. His musical achievements broke American racial barriers and made him a dominant figure worldwide. Through his songs, music videos, concerts, and fashion, he transformed visual performance in popular music, popularizing street dance moves such as the moonwalk, the robot, and the anti-gravity lean. Jackson is often deemed the greatest entertainer of all time.

The eighth of ten children in the Jackson family, he made his public debut at age six as the lead singer of the Jackson 5. Jackson rose to solo stardom with *Off the Wall* (1979) and achieved unprecedented global success with *Thriller* (1982), the best-selling album in history. The music videos for "Thriller", "Beat It", and "Billie Jean" redefined the medium. *Bad* (1987) was the first album to produce five US Billboard Hot 100 number-one singles: "I Just Can't Stop Loving You", "Bad", "The Way You Make Me Feel", "Man in the Mirror", and "Dirty Diana". *Dangerous* (1991) and *HIStory* (1995) were also successful. Jackson's final album, *Invincible* (2001), is the most expensive ever made.

From the mid-1980s, Jackson came under public scrutiny for his relationships, lifestyle, and changing appearance. He was accused of sexually abusing a child in 1993 and settled out of court in 1994. In 2005, he was tried and acquitted on other child sexual abuse charges. While preparing for *This Is It*, a series of comeback concerts, he died in 2009 from an overdose of propofol administered by his personal physician, Conrad Murray. His death caused unprecedented surges in internet traffic and a spike in music sales. Posthumous Jackson releases include the documentary *Michael Jackson's This Is It* (2009) and the albums *Michael* (2010) and *Xscape* (2014). The 2019 documentary *Leaving Neverland* detailed further child sexual abuse allegations against Jackson.

Jackson is one of the best-selling music artists of all time, with estimated sales of more than 500 million records worldwide as a solo artist.[nb 2] He is one of three musicians, alongside Paul McCartney and Phil Collins, to have sold more than 100 million records both as a solo artist and as a principal member of a band. He scored 13 number-one singles on the Billboard Hot 100 and is the only artist to have a US top-ten single in six decades. His accolades include 13 Grammy Awards, the Grammy Legend Award, the Grammy Lifetime Achievement Award, 26 American Music Awards, 12 World Music Awards, 8 MTV Video Music Awards, 6 Brit Awards, and 3 US presidential honors. He was inducted into the Rock and Roll Hall of Fame twice, as well as the Songwriters Hall of Fame and the Dance Hall of Fame. Having donated an estimated \$500 million, Jackson is credited with setting a standard for celebrity charity. The 2026 film *Michael* is the highest-grossing biographical film of all time, while Jackson's music catalog remains the highest-selling for any solo musician.